PROJECT ELDRIN

CHAPTER 1

The Gathering Storm

PRIVATE BOOK LAYOUT DRAFT

Storm-broken ruins. A hunter in mourning. A city holding its breath while something ancient, twisted, and personal waits in the dark.

Rain slid down monuments from a world long dead. Lightning flashed, and for a heartbeat the towers returned in full, vast silhouettes looming over streets now strangled by vines and shadow. Once, this had been a city. Now it was a carcass.

Beneath one of the ancient towers, a cloaked figure sat with his knees drawn to his chest, hoarding what little warmth he could from the storm.

The cloak was torn. Red-stained bandages showed through the frayed gaps. Beside him, within easy reach, lay a katana in a dark leather sheath, pristine in a way nothing else in the city was. His eyes were shut. His breathing rose and fell with the rain.

Peace never lasted long in a world like this.

A guttural cry tore through the dark, followed by a distant scream that bounced between the old skyscrapers. The sound was wrong. Not animal. Not human. Something fouler than either. The figure's eyes snapped open, and his hand found the katana at once.

It found me faster this time...

He lowered his hood.

Kaeden's violet eyes caught the rainwater gathering at his feet. They were tired eyes, but alert. He reached into his cloak, pulled out a cracked device, and tapped the dead-looking screen.

It flickered awake. Scratches and fractures veined the display, obscuring parts of the readout. Kaeden exhaled through his nose and studied the damaged interface.

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▒▒ OPERATOR: KAEDEN
▒▒ STATUS: ALIVE
▒▒ ELDRIN LEVELS: 28%▒▒

▒▒ RANK: [⚠ ▒▒▒▒▒▒] ▒▒

COMMUNICATI▒N MODULE ERROR
SYSTEM STABILITY: ▒CRITICAL▒
MAI▒▒ENANCE REQUIRED
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Kaeden frowned. His Eldrin levels were still too low. He couldn't afford to sit here much longer, not with those sounds closing in. His gaze dropped to the error warning.

"Still down, huh?" he muttered. Guess I did a number on it last time. ..

Then he caught the old photo half-buried beneath the cracks in the display. Four figures. Better days. His expression softened for only a moment.

Simpler times.

He killed the thought before it could linger.

"Dammit, my Eldrin's barely recovered."

He dragged his backpack closer and rummaged through it until he found a gun-shaped injector fitted with a glowing violet vial. He pressed it against his skin and pulled the trigger. The device hissed. The vial emptied in an instant.

"Eldrin levels at 38%," the device announced.

Kaeden watched the number stabilize and clenched his jaw. My last vial. Better make it count.

He stowed the injector, tightened the strap across his shoulder, and let his fingers rest for a moment on the hilt of the katana. Its presence steadied him.

He had been waiting for this.

Kaeden drew in a long breath, filling his lungs with cold rain and rust. The city around him was dark and ruined, but not dead. Somewhere beneath the silence and decay, it still had a pulse.

As long as I'm still breathing, I'll keep fighting. For them. For me. For whatever's left of this world. And for you.

He rose and stepped back into the storm.

The ruins swallowed him almost at once. Rusted street signs leaned at broken angles. Vines strangled old buildings. Lightning flashed across crumbling facades, and shadows lurched over the streets like things trying to remember how to live.

At an old intersection, dead traffic lights flickered weakly through curtains of rain. Rusted cars had sunk into the earth. Storefronts stood shattered and hollow, mannequins still frozen behind broken glass like pale ghosts that had forgotten how to leave.

Then the device flared in his hand.

"Warning: Multiple Lower-Class Threats Detected!"

The ground writhed.

Scraplings burst from cracks in the road and from pools of violet ooze, snapping and skittering toward him in a frenzy of teeth and malformed limbs. Their shrill cries ricocheted through the intersection.

"Scraplings," Kaeden said, and a faint smile touched his mouth.

The first wave launched itself at him all at once, trampling over its own kind in its hunger. Kaeden stood calm in the middle of it, almost still. He breathed once, slow and deep.

Calm.

His eyes opened.

Then he moved.

He kept the katana sheathed and used the hilt like a hammer, smashing one Scrapling into another hard enough to send a shockwave through the swarm. Bodies burst into swirling black mist with thin, dying wails. He pivoted, slipped past a lunge, and drove a sharp kick sideways, clearing space around himself.

For a few seconds the fight became rhythm. Step. Turn. Strike. Break.

He grinned as another Scrapling crashed into its packmates and burst apart.

Then more came.

Too many.

And worse, they were moving with purpose.

Kaeden's grin faded. Scraplings don't coordinate like this... This has to be its doing.

If he stayed in close and fought them one by one, they would bury him.

The creatures shrieked and pressed in, their voices taking on a mocking edge. Kaeden's thumb nudged the katana free. Violet fire rushed along the blade.

"Time to change the game."

He surged forward.

This time he cut.

The katana tore through the horde in streaks of violet flame. Kaeden's pupils narrowed to slits. His teeth sharpened. Every swing burned hotter than the last, and each Scrapling he split apart burst into fire and fragments that showered the ones behind it.

"Tear and burn!"

He carved a path through them at blistering speed, all heat and motion and violent grace. The air filled with the stink of scorched metal and the thin, maddened screams of dying things. By the time the last of them fell apart into smoking residue, the intersection was a graveyard of black mist and embers.

Kaeden flicked the blade clean. The flames recoiled into the metal as if dragged back by an unseen breath. He wiped the edge with his sleeve and slid the katana home. The final trace of light vanished into the sheath.

He exhaled, and violet smoke drifted from his mouth. His eyes softened. His teeth dulled.

"That never gets old."

Kaeden stood among the wreckage while rain hissed against cooling metal. Around him, where the Scraplings had died, small clusters of crystal glittered in the dark.

Eldrite.

He knelt and gathered the crystals into a pouch at his waist. Each one mattered. Refined back at HQ, they could become Eldrosa. More vials. More time.

He held one shard up to the weak light and watched it catch the storm in its core.

"This should be enough for a few more," he murmured. "Once I get back."

He sealed the pouch and rose.

The rain had grown heavier. So had the sound ahead of him.

Kaeden adjusted his cloak and moved deeper into the city. He had what he needed for now: Eldrite, a plan, and enough strength left to see it through.

The ruins opened for him like an old wound. He knew these streets. Knew the rhythm of broken ground beneath his boots. Whatever waited ahead, he would face it.

He had to.

He checked the device one more time.

"Eldrin levels at 36%."

Kaeden gave a small nod. "Not bad."

Ahead, the storm tightened. Lightning hammered down across the broken rooftops, striking old antennae and skeletal towers. He slipped the device away and kept moving.

Then the sound came again.

At first it was only a low rumble, like an engine trying to turn over in a throat too ruined to support it. Then it twisted into something living.

Human weeping.

Hysterical laughter.

Animal snarls.

The hiss of something serpentine.

The howl of wind forced through shattered steel.

All of it layered together until the city itself seemed to recoil.

Kaeden felt the sound in his bones before he fully heard it. Buildings around him groaned as if bracing. Stone cracked. Old glass shook loose from weakened frames and rained down in brittle shards.

The pressure in his skull built with every step.

Too close.

He tightened his grip on the katana and forced a breath through his lungs.

"Stay focused."

Then he ran.

Eldrin surged into his muscles, and the city blurred around him. He vaulted collapsed walls, kicked off buckled concrete, swung from hanging beams, and let his body remember what fear tried to interrupt.

For a moment there was freedom in it.

The ruins fell away. The storm thinned. He moved with the ease of someone who had once belonged to motion itself.

Then memory cut through him.

Not the city as it was now, but the city as it had been.

Alive.

Bright.

He saw himself younger, lighter, racing across rooftops with three other figures at his side. The kind of memory that hurts most because it arrives already disappearing.

Then the sound found him again, and the past was gone.

He reached the junkyard just as the storm broke harder overhead.

Rusted metal rose in crooked heaps. Broken vehicles lay half-swallowed by mud and scrap. Piles of machinery sagged into one another like collapsed bones. To anyone else, it might have looked like a dead end.

To Kaeden, it looked exactly the way he needed it to.

He slipped beneath a rusted sheet-metal shelter barely sturdy enough to stand. Rain hammered above him. For the first time since dusk, he had a sliver of cover.

He set down his backpack and pulled out his journal. The leather cover had stayed dry. Barely.

His pencil moved fast across the page.

Scraplings.

Their twisted limbs.

Their movement patterns.

The way they had worked together.

He sketched arrows between rough shapes and wrote the question that had been following him since the intersection.

Why?

Then beneath it:

Is it because of it?

He tapped the pencil against the paper and listened to the rain hammer the roof.

For now, that was the only answer he had.

He dug an energy bar from his bag, tore it open with his teeth, and ate while flipping through older pages. Sketches stared back at him from the margins. Distorted creatures. Glimpsed shapes. Half-seen things from darker roads than this one. Notes crowded beside them in tight, impatient handwriting.

Questions. Patterns. Warnings.

He came back to the Scraplings and stared at the page a while longer.

The creature was still out there.

He could feel it.

But for a few brief minutes, under the drumming roof and with the storm between them, he had room enough to think.

He snapped the journal shut, tucked it away, and leaned back against the wall. The katana rested close enough to reach without looking.

Only then did the exhaustion hit him in full.

His body ached with the dull persistence of old wounds and fresh bruises layered over one another. He had been moving for days, fighting, hunting, resting in stolen minutes and never in peace. The rain became rhythm. The metal roof turned the storm into something almost hypnotic.

His eyes grew heavy.

He tried to resist it.

Failed.

For just a little while, Kaeden let himself drift.

Sleep took him roughly.

Dreams, or memories pretending to be dreams, carried him backward.

He stood in an academy of glass and light, the air alive with energy. Three others moved nearby, familiar in ways that hurt, their faces vivid one moment and blurred the next.

The scene shifted.

A training room.

Younger Kaeden moved with a simple practice staff, still rough, still all force and hunger. Around him, the others flowed through drills with effortless precision, their practice weapons tracing clean arcs through the air. Laughter echoed off polished walls as they pushed one another harder.

Then the cafeteria.

Trays stacked with food. Voices overlapping. The careless noise of people who still believed tomorrow belonged to them.

Then another shift.

A grand hall. Rows of cadets. An instructor stepping forward with an ornate case in both hands.

Kaeden stepped toward it under the weight of every eye in the room.

Inside, something gleamed.

He reached for the weapon and felt it before he fully touched it. A perfect answer in his hands. Weight, balance, pull. Not unfamiliar, not exactly. More like recognition arriving all at once.

Then his gaze lifted.

Across the hall, another cadet stood with a katana.

Their eyes met.

Just for a heartbeat.

A challenge. A question. A beginning.

The memory dissolved before he could hold it.

Kaeden jerked awake.

Rain hammered the roof. His heart pounded hard enough to hurt.

"Damn..."

He had slept longer than he meant to.

Worse, the air had changed.

It was thicker now. Heavier. Charged with a dread that had not been there before. He grabbed the katana, and the familiar weight grounded him at once. His muscles tightened. Every nerve sharpened.

And still there was something else.

Deep within his cloak, hidden from sight, something waited.

Whatever peace sleep had given him vanished the moment he stepped out from under the shelter.

Rain hit him cold and hard. The air itself felt worse. It pressed against his chest like deep water.

The creature's presence was no longer only a sound. It was a force.

Every breath came harder. Every noise it made scraped through him like claws dragged over exposed bone.

Kaeden moved toward the center of the junkyard anyway, katana in hand, every step an act of will.

Then he saw it.

A nightmare waiting in the rain.

It stood half-veiled in shadow, a grotesque union of flesh, metal, and bone, too unstable to seem real and too deliberate to be called mindless. It shifted even when still, as if it could not settle on a single shape.

Its arms ended in taloned claws that looked almost human until they moved. Its legs bent in the wrong places, stretched too long, and carried it with a disturbing fluidity. Sinew rolled across its torso beneath matted fur and pale, sickly skin. Its face was worse: human features twisted into parody, yellow eyes burning inside sockets too deep and too hollow, a mouth spread wide with a mess of animal fangs and disturbingly human teeth.

Mechanical sounds ground inside it.

Gears.

Wires.

Something metal trying to escape from inside something once alive.

From its back jutted rusted appendages like additional limbs, ending in jagged blades. Rain bent away from its body. The ground cracked beneath each step as though even the earth wanted no part of it.

Kaeden tightened his grip on the katana. His pulse hammered in his ears, but he held his ground.

This was it.

The thing that had been hunting him as surely as he had been hunting it.

Its head twitched toward him. Yellow eyes locked on. A low growl rose from somewhere deep within its shifting frame, carrying the sound of too many throats at once.

Kaeden flicked the katana with his thumb.

Violet fire bloomed along the blade.

The Eldrin moved through him at once, sharper now, darker. His pupils narrowed. His teeth lengthened. Heat pushed back against the creature's suffocating aura, and for a moment the pressure in the air eased.

The beast lunged.

It crossed the distance with impossible speed, tearing through the junkyard in a spray of shattered concrete and flying metal. Kaeden twisted aside and answered with a clean slash. Violet flame opened along its side.

The creature howled. The sound was half machine, half animal, and all fury.

Its arm came around hard enough to break him if it landed clean. Kaeden caught the strike on his blade. Pain exploded up his arm. He was driven backward, boots skidding in rain and grime, but he stayed on his feet.

That was enough.

He did not need to overpower it.

He only needed to lead it.

Kaeden gave ground through the labyrinth of rusted metal and broken machinery, drawing it deeper with every cut and near miss. He fought like a man being cornered.

He was not.

Every retreat was measured. Every opening he left was bait.

The creature adapted as they clashed. Plates of bone and metal hardened where he struck. Its rhythm changed. Its shape sharpened around the fight. Then, when Kaeden vaulted aside to avoid another sweeping blow, a tail lashed out from its shifting frame, fast and unexpected.

It caught him across the ribs and threw him into a heap of twisted scrap.

Pain tore through his side. Air left his lungs in a single broken gasp.

"Eldrin levels at 20%," the device announced.

Kaeden forced himself up before the darkness at the edge of his vision could settle in. Blood ran warm from a cut above his brow. He wiped it away with the back of his hand and braced as the creature came again.

No time for pain.

No time for doubt.

The next impact nearly tore the katana from his grip. Then another. Then another. The beast pressed him hard, driving him back through the narrow corridor of wreckage, never letting him reset, never letting him breathe.

"Eldrin levels at 10%."

His movements slowed. Not by much. Enough.

The creature noticed.

Its assault sharpened at once. Claws, blades, teeth, the tail whipping in from blind angles. Kaeden gave back only what he had to, parried what he could, and kept his eyes on the far edge of the yard.

Almost there.

The beast backhanded him across the chest and tore through cloak and flesh. He staggered, vision swimming.

"Eldrin levels at 5%."

Still he moved.

Still he drew it in.

The creature lunged again. Kaeden ducked beneath the strike and cut deep into its side, driving it forward.

That was the step he needed.

The trap sprang.

Metal rods burst from beneath the junk, punching up through the creature's limbs and underbelly. Disguised as refuse, forged with Eldrin, they locked it in place just as the storm broke directly overhead.

Kaeden raised his eyes to the sky.

"Activate."

Lightning answered.

It came down in a white roar, struck the rods, and ripped through the beast in chained arcs of blinding energy. Ozone flooded the air. Flesh cooked. Metal screamed. The creature convulsed, thrashing against the spikes as raw power tore through it again and again.

For the first time, it suffered.

For the first time, Kaeden heard fear in its voice.

But it still would not die.

Its body writhed against the lightning, then began to shed itself. Burned flesh tore away in wet strips. Its frame shrank, tightened, sharpened. The thing that emerged from the ruin of its larger body was leaner, faster, built for one final kill.

Then it tore itself free.

It landed on all fours, gouging deep furrows through the junkyard floor, and launched at him with what it had left.

Kaeden forced himself upright.

Every muscle in his body screamed. Dark spots swam across his sight. His limbs felt leaden, distant. But this was the moment he had dragged them both toward since the hunt began, and he refused to collapse before it arrived.

The creature closed the distance in a heartbeat.

Kaeden shifted the katana into a reverse grip.

With his free hand, he reached into his cloak.

Metal unfolded with a heavy, final click.

The scythe opened in his grasp.

Its curved blade glowed with a spectral, sickly light. The air around him changed at once. Violet fire around the katana deepened, then took on a ghostly blue undertone. An icy ring formed within his eyes.

His device let out one final warning.

"Eldrin levels are depleted."

Then:

"Switching to life essence."

The screen died.

Something colder than rain rolled out from Kaeden in a wave. The creature felt it. It hesitated for the first time, then threw itself at him anyway, desperate now, violent in the way cornered things are violent.

Kaeden met it.

Katana and scythe moved together, crossing the charge in a shower of sparks. The impact drove him backward, but once he found his footing he took the fight back from it entirely.

He became impossible to follow.

Steel flashed.

Spectral light tore through rain.

The creature struck and found only absence. Kaeden slipped beneath claws, around blades, through openings too small to exist. Every answer he gave was precise. Every wound he opened mattered.

When the beast clipped him, he did not slow.

When it roared, he came on harder.

By the end, fear had entered its movements fully. It gathered itself for one last desperate strike, dark energy crackling along its limbs in a final attempt to erase him before he could finish what he had started.

Kaeden saw it.

Saw the fear.

Saw the end.

He crossed both weapons before him. Frost laced the ground at his feet, only to be swallowed by rising violet flame.

Then he moved.

"Eldritch Reaping!"

The words tore out of him as both weapons came down in a single sweeping arc. Violet fire and spectral cold fused into one violent wave and hit the creature head-on.

Light swallowed the junkyard.

The beast screamed.

Its body came apart under the force of the strike, flesh and metal peeling away in burning strips. Kaeden hit the ground hard on the other side of it, one knee buckling beneath him. The aura around him flickered, guttered, and died. His eyes returned to normal. His teeth dulled. The strength left him all at once.

He coughed blood into the rain.

The storm washed ash and smoke aside.

Then he saw the face beneath what remained.

A pale face.

A familiar one.

Soft even now. Almost peaceful. Touched by the faintest trace of a smile.

No.

The thought hit him too late and all at once. The katana slipped from his fingers. The scythe followed, striking the soaked ground with a dead metallic sound.

"No..."

The word barely made it out of him.

He stumbled forward and dropped to his knees beside her, hands shaking too hard to reach for her at first. Memory hit in flashes so sharp they hurt: her laughter, her voice, the promises made in quiet places when the world had still seemed survivable.

How?

How had she become this?

Who had done this to her?

Rain poured over both of them. Kaeden's vision blurred, and this time it had nothing to do with blood.

He touched her at last.

Cold skin.

Stillness.

Reality.

He pulled her into his arms and held her there while the storm broke over the junkyard and over what was left of him.

The victory was hollow. The hunt had ended exactly where he had driven it to end, and it had still become something worse than failure.

As he held her, questions crashed through him harder than any blow the creature had landed.

How had she been turned into that thing?

Who was behind it?

And how many more had been twisted the same way?

Rain washed the ash away. It did nothing for the grief.

The battle was over.

The war had only just begun.

Kaeden lowered his head, held her tighter, and made the vow in silence.

He would find the truth.

No matter what it cost.